

Orthodoxy 201

Origins

- ◆ The origins of the words and sacred acts of this central Mystery of our Faith are very well known. The Divine Eucharist traces its origins directly to the Eucharistic Meal the Lord had with His Disciples in the upper room in Jerusalem before His betrayal.
- ◆ The events are narrated by all three synoptic Evangelists and by Saint Paul.
- ◆ We perpetuate this Meal because the Lord told us through His disciples *“do this in remembrance of me”*. Since then, *“on the first day of the week,”* the church has been gathering together *“to break bread”* Acts 20:7
- ◆ As we read in acts, the disciples continued to worship in the temple and the synagogue. To this worship practice they added the Eucharistic Meal. The typical pattern of worship for the early believers was synagogue worship on the Sabbath morning, then gathering together again on the same evening after sunset, which was already *“the next day,”* the Lord’s Day to share the Eucharistic Meal.
- ◆ In the early church, the Lord's supper was celebrated at the end of a fellowship meal called Agape/love. After the persecutions (Acts 8:1), the Christians carried on the synagogue worship in some form, to which they added the Eucharist.
- ◆ The liturgical structure was simple: a Bishop presided, surrounded by presbyters. *“Psalms, hymns and spiritual songs”* (Eph. 5:19; Col. 3:16) were chanted. Lessons from the prophets were read (to which later on were added the Epistles and Gospel passages). A sermon was given and then the deacons carried in and placed on the supper table the gifts that were offered by the people, that being the bread and the wine.
- ◆ The Anaphora - prayer of offering and Thanksgiving then took place and the elements were consecrated.
- ◆ “Ana” and “Phora” is to offer as a sacrifice, to offer up. It is used 5 times in the NT Heb. 7:27, 13:15; James 2:21; 1 Pet. 2:5 and 2:24. The equivalent Latin word is oblation.
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- ◆ Saint Clement's letter to the Corinthians 95 – 98 AD, contains what may have been a Liturgical prayer.
- ◆ Saint Justin the martyr, 165 AD, described the first Eucharistic Service including prayers, readings, sermon, kiss of peace, Anaphora and Holy Communion in many details...
- ◆ *“after we have thus cleansed the person who believes and has joined our ranks, we lead him into where those we call ‘brethren’ are assembled to offer prayers in common for ourselves, for him who has just been enlightened, and for all everywhere. It is our desire, now that we have come to know the truth, to be found worthy of doing good deeds and obeying the commandments, and thus to obtain eternal salvation. This food [we partake] we call ‘Eucharist’, and no one may share it unless he believes that our teaching is true, and has been cleansed in the bath of forgiveness for sin and rebirth, and lives as Christ taught.”* Apology 1 ch.65.1, 66.1
- ◆ The Apostolic Tradition of St. Hippolytus of Rome (215 AD) describes the Divine Liturgy in detail. Our Liturgy today is essentially the same eucharistic service of these first Christians which the church kept faithfully and transmitted to us in all its integrity.
- ◆ The core of the liturgy as we have it in our service today stems from the rubrics and texts from around the 9th century. St Germanos of Constantinople

- ✦ Participation in The Divine Liturgy is a journey into union with God in His Kingdom.
- ✦ The beginning of The Divine Liturgy has the main celebrant standing in front of the Holy Altar, venerating the book of the Holy Gospel and there he elevates high above while making a sign of the cross saying...
- ✦ The first exclamation of the Divine Liturgy reveals the key to the entire celebration:
- ✦ ***Blessed is the Kingdom of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, now and ever and unto ages of ages.***
- ✦ With these words the celebrant announces the source and the goal of the Divine Service of the People of God, the very context and contents of the entire Liturgical action.
- ✦ It is the Kingdom of God brought to the world by Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and Mystically reigning already in the faithful disciples of Christ by the presence and power of the Holy Spirit.
- ✦ The opening proclamation of The Divine Liturgy is the announcement of our destination and goal in life - again that being the Kingdom of God - and The Divine Liturgy is our pilgrimage toward His Kingdom and a participation in His Kingdom.
- ✦ This announcement brings out the ultimate choice that the Lord Jesus Christ asks everyone to make...
- ✦ do I “seek first the Kingdom of God and His righteousness”?
- ✦ By saying “**Blessed is the Kingdom of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit now and forever into the ages of ages...** With the response coming from the faithful **Amen** which means – “so be it”, “let it be”, “it is true” - we can now say that we HAVE SET the Kingdom of God as THE highest priority in our lives.
- ✦ Time stops in the Divine Liturgy; we do not measure it in minutes and seconds. We transcend time, and we transcend all the roles we have; we cease to be teachers, doctors or spouses, parents, though we stay as children, children of God in the presence of our Father! Heaven on Earth!

The Kingdom

- ✦ The Kingdom of God is eternal life in communion with God in loving obedience to His Divine Will. It is life in union with the Blessed Trinity; life lived toward the Father, through the Son, in the Holy Spirit. It is the life which Christ has given to all by His Incarnation, Crucifixion, Resurrection, and Glorification. It is the life to be lived already in this world by the People of God.
- ✦ To bless the Kingdom of God means: love it as one’s most precious possession.

- ✦ Only the Divine Liturgy and the other Mysteries/Sacraments and services of the Church which were originally integrated into the Eucharistic celebration, such as Baptism, Chrismation, and Marriage begin with the solemn “Blessed is the Kingdom”
- ✦ The Liturgy is a school of prayer, teaching us how to pray and what to pray for.
- ✦ After the opening proclamation, the Great Litany is prayed. This litany begins every Liturgical service of the Orthodox Church, as well as virtually all Mysteries/Sacraments and special services. It is the all-embracing prayer of the Church for everyone and everything.
- ✦ It is a series of requests to God. The very first thing we pray for is for “the peace of God that surpasses all understanding” (Philippians 4:7) to be given to us, a state of inner peace, the riding of our minds and hearts of every obsession and anxiety, all hostile feelings and fear, in order to worship the living God in a state of inner calm, trusting attentiveness and quiet joy.
- ✦ When we pray, we must pray in peace!
- ✦ The first petitions says “In Peace let us pray to the Lord”
- ✦ The next 10 petitions are addressed to the people, not directly to God. This is why they all have the word “For” in front. In many of these petitions we are praying for very concrete human needs.

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- ✦ Again, it needs to be stated that the petitions are not addressed to God but to the people!
- ✦ **It is the people who, with their reply, turn them into prayers to God**
- ✦ By responding with that most common and compact of all prayers of the Orthodox faithful:
- ✦ Lord, Have Mercy
- ✦ We therefore see that without participation of the people of God these petitions are not complete prayers.
- ✦ By adding the response and the reply it becomes a full prayer great and fervor with penitence and humility.
- ✦ We should shout out this great prayer from the roots of our hearts just as the first Christians did. Just as those who called to Christ to heal them as He walked by them. **It's not just for the chanters or for the choir to pray for us.**
- ✦ They cannot do this anymore than eat for us!
- ✦ Is it not a word used by condemned people who asked for clemency? Yes, and that is our case! We will not comprehend the full impact of our petitions unless we realize that the word rendered by “servants”. In the same sense then we realize that *“this is indeed the supplication of the condemned who have no possible defense and no justification to put forward.”* St Nicholas Kabasilas
- ✦ But why do we ask for mercy at each petition? Saint Simeon of Thessalonica answers *“this intercession is appropriate, since we should not ask for anything except for mercy, as we have neither boldness nor access to offer anything as our own, nor to request anything as such... So, as sinners and condemned through sin we cannot, nor dare, say anything to our loving Master except ‘have mercy.’”*
- ✦ Lord have mercy shows three things:
 - ✦ 1. That worship is offered to God not only by the Priest but by the People together with him.
 - ✦ 2. We declare that we receive all the earthly and heavenly goods we need freely from God
 - ✦ 3. That generally in order to be saved we need the Divine Mercy
- ✦ *“For without the mercy of God there is no salvation... These words Lord have mercy expresses our true place before God and the entire mystery of our salvation”* – Metropolitan Dionysios of Kozane

- ◆ Finally, after asking God for the deliverance from everything harmful and negative and for His Divine help, salvation, mercy and protection, the people remember the Theotokos (Mother of God) and all the Saints and commend themselves and each other and all their life to Christ their God.
- ◆ The Saints, those men and women, who throughout the centuries and in every culture loved God more than all, became witnesses of the Good News of Jesus Christ in the power of the Holy Spirit, and remained faithful to God to the completion of their earthly life, often at the cost of losing their life. They have been glorified and have been set up as true role models for us and for all to look up to and replicate.
- ◆ The Great Litany then ends with a doxology proper to the Holy Trinity to Whom are due all glory, honor and worship forever. Once more the prayer is completed by the Amen of the people.

The Antiphons

- ◆ After the Great Litany, psalm verses are chanted proper to the particular occasion. These psalm verses are called the antiphons because they were, and sometimes still are sung by the people in two choirs, each responding antiphonally to the other. There are three sets of antiphons at each Divine Liturgy.
- ◆ *“The laity... turn to psalmody, and, being now divided into two, they chant to one another alternatively. Having allowed one to commence the song, the rest of them maintaining the balance; and thus in variety of psalmody they divide up the night praying among themselves”* St. Basil the Great (379 AD)
- ◆ Historically the antiphons were chanted by the people in solemn procession to the church where the Divine Liturgy of the day was to be celebrated. Today, although they are now part of the service itself, they still form the joyful preparation for entrance into the worship of Christ through the Word of the Gospel and the offering and receiving of Holy Communion.
- ◆ “Through the Intercessions of the Theotokos (Mother of God) Savior, save us.”
- ◆ “Save us O Son of God, Risen from the dead (among the Saints Glorified) we sing to you: Alleluia.” This may also have a various theme when celebrating a Major Feast of the Lord – Pascha, Christmas, Theophany, Presentation
- ◆ Why “again and again” ??? - the Lord does not say ask... Seek...knock,” but keep asking...keep seeking... keep knocking. Asking again and again is a reminder to US – that we need to pray with persistence and perseverance!

Hymn “Only Begotten Son and Word of God”

- ✦ The hymn is a compendium of the Creed; in fact it is often referred to as the *short Creed*.
- ✦ It is a hymn of faith in the divinity of Christ and His Incarnation, Crucifixion, and Resurrection as “One of the Holy Trinity” for the salvation of humankind.
- ✦ The hymn was composed in the 6th century, reportedly by the holy emperor Justinian himself, who was the ruler of the Roman Empire (482-565AD) and builder of the Temple of Holy Wisdom in Constantinople. Theophanes, an ecclesiastical writer of the 9th century, tells us that Emperor Justinian had composed the use of this hymn, which originally served as an entrance hymn.

The Small Entrance

- ✦ During the singing of the third antiphon, the Hymn of the Saint of the day or the Resurrectional Hymn on a Sunday, the so-called Small Entrance is made. The Small Entrance is the solemn procession of the clergy from the Holy Altar with the Book of the Gospel
- ✦ Remember from last week –
- ✦ the Small Entrance for the beginning of Christ's public ministry
- ✦ After the exclamation: “Wisdom! Let Us Attend!” the clergy enter the royal gates of the Icon Screen (this as we know it now is from the 14th Cent) while all sing the Hymn of Entrance:
- ✦ *Come, let us worship and bow down before Christ. Save us, O Son of God Risen from the dead (or other) we sing to you Alleluia. Praise God*
- ✦ The Small Entrance is the first significant movement of the Divine Liturgy. It follows the primary liturgical action which is the gathering of the faithful into the one community of the Church of God.
- ✦ The Small Entrance is the movement of the entire Church through its Head Jesus Christ, in the person of the celebrant, to the Altar which symbolizes the Kingdom of God. It is the movement made possible by the Gospel of Christ, the Way to the Kingdom. It can only be accomplished by following Jesus, the Living Word of God in human flesh (Jn 1.1–18).
- ✦ We cannot come to God the Father without first coming to Christ and we get to the Father THROUGH Christ. (John 14:6). We cannot have communion with God if we do not fulfill His Commandments.
- ✦ Thus it is the Gospel of Christ, the Son and Word of God, which takes us into the realm of the Father and into the eternal life of the Blessed Trinity whose Kingdom we enter and experience in the Divine Liturgy of the Church.

- ◆ The book of the gospel is a sacramental embodiment of Christ and in the liturgy and is kissed and treated like an icon of Christ, an icon written in words, not paint.
- ◆ While the clergy are still before the Holy Altar Table, the people sing the troparia and kontakia (short season hymn) of the day. These are hymns which calls to mind the life of those who chose to be HOLY/SET APART , celebrated liturgically at the particular gathering.
- ◆ There then follows the singing of the Thrice-Holy Hymn of the angels which perpetually resounds in the presence of the Kingdom of God. “Holy God! Holy Mighty! Holy Immortal! Have mercy on us!” (Is 6.1–5).

Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal

- ◆ What does it mean for us to sing this ancient hymn?
- ◆ It signifies that the God whom we praise is completely, totally and utterly transcendent. The One, True and Living God stands outside the created universe of time and space as we know it. Because of this we can never fully grasp the Divine reality and must approach God in worship with a sense of reverence and awe. God is, as the Liturgy will later say in one of its prayers, “ineffable, beyond comprehension, invisible, beyond understanding, existing forever and always the same, You and Your Only Begotten Son and Your Holy Spirit.”
- ◆ God, the creator of the universe Whom we cannot even begin to comprehend, has chosen to reveal Himself to us as complete and total Love, Truth, Light and Life in the person of Jesus, the *“Christ in whom the fullness of the deity dwelt in bodily form.”* (Col 2:9)
- ◆ St Nicholas Cabasilas (1322-1392) says that in singing this hymn during the liturgy “human beings and angels form one church and one choir”. During the celebration of the liturgy, heaven and earth intersect and our worship here becomes an icon of the worship going on around the throne of God in heaven (Rev. 4:1-10).
- ◆ To call God thrice holy implies his absolute purity. For us this carries moral connotations for “Your eyes are too pure to look upon evil and you cannot tolerate wrong” (Habakkuk 1:13). The holiness of God demands repentance: the cleansing and purification of one's mind and heart, and the consecration of one's life in love to him.
- ◆ “Be holy because I, the Lord your God, am holy” Lev 19:2 he said this prior to issuing the commandment “love your neighbor as yourself” 19:18
- ◆ The first liturgical use of this hymn is attested by the 4th Ecumenical Council in 451 AD.

- ◆ Prayer of the Thrice Holy Hymn: *O Holy God, who is resting among the holy ones, praised by the Seraphim with the thrice-holy voice, glorified by the Cherubim, and worshiped by every celestial power, You have brought all things into being out of nothing. You have created man according to Your image and likeness and adorned him with all the gifts of Your grace. You give wisdom and understanding to the one who asks, and You overlook not the sinner, but have set repentance as the way of salvation. You have granted us, Your humble and unworthy servants, to stand even at this hour before the glory of Your holy Altar of sacrifice and to offer to You due worship and praise. Master, accept the Trisagion Hymn also from the lips of us sinners, and visit us in Your goodness. Forgive all our voluntary and involuntary transgressions, sanctify our souls and bodies, and grant that we may worship You in holiness all the days of our lives, through the intercessions of the holy Theotokos and of all the saints who have pleased You throughout the ages.*

Hearing Scripture

- ◆ In any conversation we hold with a person, there are times when we speak, and times when we listen. Liturgical dialogue is no different. Up to this point, we have basically offered petitions and prayers praising God and asking him to care for our daily needs. Now comes the high point of the first half of the liturgy.
- ◆ It is time for us to be silent and listen. We will hear an epistle and gospel reading. And the purpose of the upcoming scripture readings is to nourish us with divine wisdom.
- ◆ We hear “**let us be attentive**”, yet when this is done many sit down and might relax while letting our minds wander. It is at this time that we should sit at the edge of our seat waiting expectantly for divine words of guidance, of nourishment, of encouragement, of correction and of strength.
- ◆ “*The scriptures were not given to us that we might have them in books, but that we might engrave them in our hearts*” St. John Chrysostom

The Epistle

- ◆ During the solemn singing of the Thrice-Holy Hymn to the Most Holy Trinity, the Clergy proceed to the High Place behind the Altar table, blessing Christ who “*sits upon the throne of glory, upon the cherubim. . .*” From this place, as we have already mentioned, the celebrant turns and blesses the people with the Peace of Christ. After the Peace is returned, the Epistle of the Divine Liturgy is chanted, usually by a layperson of the Church.

- ◆ The Epistle reading in traditional Church language is called the the Apostolic reading. This is so since the reading may be taken from the Acts of the Apostles as well as from one of the Apostolic letters of the New Testament scriptures. The word epistle means letter.
- ◆ There is a series of epistle readings prescribed in regular order for each day of the Church Year, with the exception of the week days of Great Lent when the Divine Liturgy is not celebrated. There are also special Epistle readings prescribed for particular Church celebrations.

The Gospel

- ◆ A reading from the Holy Gospel follows the reading of the Epistle at the Divine Liturgy. In between these two proclamations, Alleluia is solemnly chanted, once more interspersed (by verses from the Psalms). At this time incense is also offered, with the incensing of the Gospel with the following prayer being prayed:
- ◆ *Shine in our hearts, O benevolent Lord, the pure light of Your divine knowledge, and open the eyes of our mind that we may comprehend the proclamations of Your Gospels. Instill in us the fear that Your blessed commandments inspire, so that, crushing carnal desires, we may seek the spiritual citizenship, thinking and doing all those things that are pleasing to You. For You, Christ our God, are the illumination of our souls and bodies, and to You we offer up glory, and to Your Father, who is without beginning, and Your all-holy, good, and life-creating Spirit, now and ever and to the ages of ages. Amen.*
- ◆ The Alleluia and the censing at this moment in the Divine Liturgy signify the very presence of God with his People, teaching them Himself through Christ the Word and the Holy Spirit (Jn 6.45). God is with men in the Church, revealing Himself and His Holy Will to the world. The Gospel is God's glad tidings of salvation, His official Good News to mankind. It contains and proclaims His presence and His power among men.
- ◆ The proclamation of the Gospel in the Church is a Mystical/Sacramental act. It is a form of man's communion with God. It is an element of the Liturgical Mystery in and through which God is united with His People, and His People with Him.
- ◆ Just as for the Epistle readings, there are prescribed readings from the Gospel for each Liturgical day of the year, as well as special readings for particular Church celebrations..